

The Precarious Professor: *Adjunct Labor, Job Insecurity, and Mental Health in Higher Education*

Over 70% of college instructors in America are contingent faculty — teaching the majority of undergraduate courses for poverty wages, with no benefits, no job security, and no voice in the institutions they serve (AFT 2022). The widespread exploitation of adjunct faculty is a deliberate structural crisis that devastates educator mental health, financial stability, and student education quality — demanding urgent reform.

We will examine what this exploitation costs students, the severe mental health consequences adjuncts endure, the starvation wages they receive despite terminal degrees, the structural causes of this systematic shift, and concrete solutions for meaningful reform.

Today's college students pay record tuition to be taught by underpaid, overworked adjuncts rather than the faculty universities advertise. To understand this injustice, we must first see what it costs students — and what it costs the teachers who serve them.

When Instructors Suffer, Students Lose

Students lose access to mentorship and consistency

- Students bond with instructors who vanish the next semester.
- High turnover destroys the continuity of mentoring relationships essential for student success and retention.
- Curriculum incoherence increases as courses are handed off semester to semester

Students are misled about who is actually teaching them

- Universities market their tenured, research-prominent faculty in recruitment materials
- In reality, most undergraduate instruction is delivered by adjuncts — a "bait-and-switch" that undermines trust and educational quality (Umbach 2007; Figlio et al. 2015)
- First-generation and marginalized students are hit hardest by this disruption. Community colleges—serving the most vulnerable populations—have the highest adjunct rates.
- 70–90% adjunct rates at community colleges (Phillippe 2024)

Precarious Employment Conditions Destroy Mental Health

Adjuncts have no safety net of any kind

- For 3 out of 4 adjuncts, employment is guaranteed only semester-to-semester — a complete lack of contract security (AFT 2022)
- No health insurance or retirement benefits — even when carrying full-time course loads; only 45% have access to employer-provided health insurance, while nearly 19% rely on Medicare/Medicaid (AFT 2022)
 - Only 14% of part-time faculty get health benefits from another employer; for 78%, their work as faculty is their primary employment, yet only a third get health insurance through their college or university (CFT 2022)

- **Government Assistance:** Nearly 25% of adjunct faculty rely on at least one public assistance program such as SNAP (food stamps), Medicaid, or the Earned Income Tax Credit (AFT 2022)
 - Nearly 20% of adjuncts rely on Medicaid because they lack access to employer-provided health insurance (AFT 2022)
- **Late Notice:** Nearly 43% of adjuncts receive teaching assignments less than one month before classes begin, making financial planning nearly impossible (Johnson & Fuesting 2026)
- **No institutional identity** — many adjuncts lack a university email address, office space, parking, or even an ID badge
 - Exclusion from professional development funds, retirement plans, and institutional support systems creates systemic invisibility
- **Unpaid Risk:** At 70% of institutions, courses are canceled if enrollment drops. Adjuncts typically receive zero compensation for the lost preparation and work. (Johnson & Fuesting 2026)
 - At 13% of institutions, low enrollment may reduce adjunct pay rates. Some places (4%) pay incrementally based on the number of students enrolled in a course.
- **Artificial Underemployment:** Three-quarters of adjuncts would gladly take additional course assignments if available, but are blocked by institutional administrative caps designed to avoid triggering benefit eligibility thresholds—creating artificial scarcity in their own employment. Under the Affordable Care Act, employers must provide health insurance to employees working more than 30 hours per week; many colleges responded by implementing strict limits on course credits and work hours per semester, deliberately capping adjuncts below full-time status to avoid insurance obligations. This practice has prompted advocacy for policy reform, exemplified by California Assembly Bill 2277, which would have raised the cap for part-time faculty to 85% of a full-time load (approximately four courses at a single community college). However, Governor Gavin Newsom vetoed the bill on September 22, 2024, arguing in his veto message that "this bill continues to create unknown, but potentially significant costs or cost pressures in the millions to tens of millions of dollars." The Association of California Community College Administrators opposed the bill, warning that "AB 2277 would infringe upon the local authority of community college districts to collectively bargain their own paid leave provisions at the district level," and noting concerns that "allowing part-time faculty members to teach more courses at a single campus could trigger the Affordable Care Act, requiring colleges to expand health care coverage for part-timers"—illustrating how the ACA itself has become a tool for institutional cost-cutting and the suppression of adjunct work opportunities (Johnson & Fuesting 2026; AFT; CalMatters)

The resulting mental health crisis is severe and well-documented

- Depression rates among adjunct faculty are 2–3 times higher than those of the general population (AFT 2020, 2022; Evans et al. 2018; Tucker et al. 2022; Levecque et al. 2017)
 - Nearly 45 percent of faculty members surveyed have put off getting needed healthcare, including mental health services, and 64 percent have forgone dental care (AFT 2020)
- Suicidal ideation has been documented among contingent faculty

A culture of shame and silence makes it worse

- The truth is we call it a teacher shortage, but in reality, we have a shortage of respect for teachers and all school staff — a shortage of the professional working conditions they deserve, and a shortage of pay for what is arguably the most important job in the world
- These are not newcomers or students seeking part-time work: most part-time faculty have an average of 13 years of experience (35% have more than 15 years; only 23% have less than five years), and three-quarters would take more work if offered (CFT 2022)
- Adjuncts are pressured to maintain the appearance of professional success — "the Performing Professor" — while privately skipping meals
- Social isolation runs deep; peers and family often don't understand or believe the reality
- The death of Margaret Mary Vojtko — an 83-year-old adjunct professor who died in poverty after decades of service — became a symbol of the crisis

Adjunct Faculty Are Paid Poverty Wages Despite Holding Advanced Degrees

Pay is shockingly low on a per-course basis

- The average pay per course is approximately \$3,000, ranging from \$2,000–5,000 (AFT 2022)
- When accounting for unpaid preparation, grading, and office hours, the real hourly wage drops to roughly \$10/hour (AFT 2022)

Annual income falls well below a living wage: "Faculty Poverty"

"Faculty poverty" refers to the growing phenomenon of highly educated college instructors living at or near the federal poverty line despite holding advanced degrees (PhDs or Master's). A significant portion of the academic workforce now relies on public assistance to survive.

The scale of the crisis: Advanced degree holders on government assistance

Based on the most recent Survey of Income and Program Participation (SIPP) and Census Bureau data, roughly 3–4% of individuals with a Master's degree or higher now receive some form of public assistance (primarily SNAP or Medicaid). This represents a dramatic increase over the past 15+ years:

Advanced Degree Recipients on Government Assistance:

Year	Master's Degrees	Professional-School Degrees	Doctorate Degrees
2007	101,682	24,864	9,776
2010	293,029	32,719	33,655
2024–25	~550,000–620,000	~45,000–55,000	~50,000–62,000

Total Advanced Degrees (Master's + Professional + Doctorate):

- 2007–2010: Roughly 135,000–330,000 recipients
- 2024–25: **~650,000–730,000 recipients** (a 240% increase from 2010)

This trajectory is staggering: in just 14 years, the number of highly educated workers relying on public assistance has more than doubled. The national trend reflects the same structural collapse that defines the adjunct crisis: even highly credentialed workers cannot survive on the wages offered in today's economy.

- More than 25% of adjuncts earn less than \$26,500 annually, which is below the federal poverty guideline for a family of four ("New AFT Report: Adjunct Faculty Remain Underpaid")
 - A typical adjunct teaching load of 3-4 courses per semester (considered "part-time" despite being functionally full-time work requiring 30-50 hours per week) yields annual earnings of \$12,000-\$30,000—well below livable wages in most areas and below the federal poverty line for a family
 - Only 15% of adjuncts report being able to comfortably cover their basic monthly expenses (AFT 2020)
 - Roughly 74% of adjuncts live paycheck to paycheck, with more than a third unable to cover all their monthly bills
- Grueling Workarounds: To escape absolute poverty, many adjuncts adopt punishing schedules:
 - "Freeway faculty" or "road scholars" teach at three or four different colleges simultaneously, often in different counties, to bypass caps on part-time hours at a single school
 - Many supplement their teaching income with low-wage gig economy work—Uber driving, bagging groceries—sometimes at the same stores where their students shop
 - Some teach up to six courses per semester—nearly double a typical full-time professor's load—just to reach survival-level income
- Professional Cost: Economic hardship directly undermines the quality of education and professional development:
 - Many "poverty-level" professors lack dedicated office space, computers, or travel funding for research

- Faculty are rationing healthcare due to a lack of or insufficient coverage (CFT 2022):
 - 63% postponed dental care/checkups
 - 44% postponed needed healthcare, including mental health services
 - 43% did not see a doctor when needed
 - 30% did not get medical tests/treatments recommended by doctors
 - 21% chose less expensive treatments than recommended
 - 19% did not fill prescriptions
 - 12% skipped/postponed rehabilitation care
 - 11% cut pills in half or skipped doses of medicine
- Melissa Bruninga-Matteau, in 2012, started a conversation regarding how she, as a white, 43-year-old single mother with a Ph.D. in medieval history who teaches two humanities courses as an adjunct professor at Yavapai College, in Prescott, Ariz., came to rely on food stamps and Medicaid
 - She said the stereotype of the people receiving such aid does not reflect reality.
 - "Recipients include growing numbers of people like her, the highly educated, whose advanced degrees have not insulated them from financial hardship." (Patton 2012)

The pay gap is a deliberate institutional choice, not a financial necessity

- College tuition has risen 169% while adjunct pay has remained stagnant (AAUP; Kezar et al.)
- University presidents regularly earn \$500,000–\$1,000,000+ annually (GAO; Chronicle of Higher Education)
- Administrative spending has ballooned while instructional budgets shrink

Shame, Silence, and Isolation

The "Performing Professor"

- Higher education uniquely exploits workers' passion, calling, and commitment. Universities leverage instructors' love of teaching, intellectual commitment to their disciplines, dedication to students, and identification as teachers and scholars to extract labor far beyond what's compensated or sustainable. "Do it for the students," "Do it for the love of learning," "Teaching is a calling, not just a job"—these narratives become justifications for exploitation, suggesting that expecting fair pay and decent conditions means you don't really care or don't belong in academia (Childress; Bousquet; Kezar et al.).
- Passion and calling are weaponized against workers, making them complicit in their own exploitation and feel guilty for expecting basic dignity (Childress; Bousquet).
- The system relies on people's hope, desperation, sunk costs, and identity. Adjuncts continue in exploitative conditions because: they hope for a tenure-track job (the academic lottery ticket—keep buying tickets even though odds are 1 in 100+), they've invested 5-10+ years in education and training (PhD plus often postdocs) and can't psychologically accept that it was for nothing (sunk cost fallacy), they identify deeply as teachers, scholars, historians, philosophers, sociologists—it's not just what they do but who they are, and they have few alternatives with specialized degrees (what does one do with a PhD in medieval literature or continental philosophy besides teach). The system exploits all of these psychological and structural vulnerabilities (Cassuto; Childress; Bousquet).

Invisible labor: Adjuncts perform vast amounts of uncompensated work

- More than 40% of contingent faculty advise students informally and, at least once a month, help students with class content that was not from the course they were assigned to teach—without compensation (AFT 2022)
- The majority hold uncompensated office hours, providing mentorship and support well beyond their paid teaching responsibilities (AFT 2022)
- Despite not being paid for it, many contingent faculty participate in the shared governance that keeps their colleges and universities functioning—serving on committees, developing curricula, and shaping institutional policy without compensation (AFT 2022)
- This unpaid labor is particularly exploitative given the poverty wages adjuncts already earn—they are expected to perform the full duties of professional faculty while being compensated as disposable labor (AFT 2022)

Food and Housing Insecurity: The Hidden Crisis

Food and housing insecurity are common, not exceptional. Some adjuncts qualify for food stamps (SNAP benefits), Medicaid, or housing assistance despite having PhDs and teaching college—the ultimate indictment of the system. Stories of adjuncts living in cars (sleeping in campus parking lots or Walmart parking lots), sleeping in campus offices (hiding from security, using gym showers), couch-surfing with friends or former students, living in cheap motels, or relying on food banks are not rare outliers sensationalized by media—they're systemic outcomes of poverty wages. Multiple adjuncts have publicly shared these experiences; many more suffer silently in shame (AFT 2020; Kenner & Bacon 2019; Goldrick-Rab et al. 2015; Childress 2019).

This Crisis Was Structurally and Deliberately Built

The shift from tenure to contingency was a historical reversal

The makeup of the US academic workforce has shifted from mostly full-time tenured or tenure-track faculty members to mostly faculty members holding contingent appointments that are ineligible for tenure (AAUP 2025).

Key statistics from fall 1987 to fall 2023:

- **Tenure-track decline:** About 32 percent of faculty members held full-time tenured or tenure-track appointments in fall 2023, compared with about 53 percent in fall 1987 (AAUP 2025)
- **Tenured positions:** About 23 percent held full-time tenured appointments, compared with about 39 percent in fall 1987 (AAUP 2025)
- **Contingent appointments:** About 68 percent of faculty members held contingent appointments in fall 2023, compared with about 47 percent in fall 1987—a complete reversal of the historical norm (AAUP 2025)
- **Part-time work:** Nearly half (49 percent) of faculty members were employed part-time in fall 2023, compared with about 33 percent in fall 1987 (AAUP 2025)

Contingency rates by institution type (Fall 2023): The percentage of faculty members holding contingent appointments ranged from about 51 percent among Research I universities to about 83 percent among associate's (community) colleges—reflecting the disproportionate reliance on contingent labor in the institutions serving the most vulnerable student populations (AAUP 2025).

Recent trends (Fall 2002 to Fall 2023): The number of faculty members holding contingent appointments increased substantially while tenure-track positions stagnated or declined:

- Full-time contingent appointments increased about 65 percent
- Full-time tenured appointments increased about 6 percent
- Full-time tenure-track appointments decreased about 7 percent
- Part-time appointments increased about 20 percent (AAUP 2025)

Contract types: Most full-time contingent faculty members are on renewable contracts, while most part-time contingent faculty members are on nonrenewable less-than-annual contracts. About 76 percent of part-time contingent faculty were on nonrenewable short-term contracts in fall 2023, while about 85 percent of full-time contingent faculty were on renewable (annual or multiyear) contracts (AAUP 2025).

Graduate student employment: US colleges and universities have increasingly relied on graduate student employees for teaching and research—the number of graduate student employees with teaching or research responsibilities increased by over 40 percent from fall 2002 to fall 2023 (AAUP 2025).

Universities engineered this shift for financial and institutional gain

AFT Contingent Faculty Quality of Work/Life Report

68 percent of faculty are in positions that are not eligible for tenure, and 48 percent hold positions that are not just "contingent" (on enrollment, funding or some other variable) but part-time.

The shift coincided with a fundamental change in how higher education was funded and managed

- Beginning in the 1980s, universities adopted a neoliberal business model, treating education as a profit center rather than a public good (Giroux 2014; Slaughter & Rhoades 2004)
- Federal support for public universities declined, shifting the burden to students through tuition and loans
- Rather than increase public funding or tuition modestly, institutions chose to cut instructional costs by replacing tenure-track positions with disposable contingent labor

The mechanism was straightforward and cynical

- As tenure-track faculty retired or left, universities simply did not replace them with permanent positions
- Instead, they hired multiple adjuncts at a fraction of the cost — a single tenure-track line (\$70,000+ with benefits) could be replaced with 4-5 adjuncts at \$12,000 each
- This allowed institutions to maintain course offerings and enrollment revenue while gutting the instructional budget
- The savings flowed upward: to administrative expansion, capital projects, and executive compensation — not back to education

The PhD Pipeline Trap enabled this exploitation

- Universities deliberately overproduce PhD graduates through their graduate programs — training far more scholars than available tenure-track positions (Larson et al. 2014)
- This creates a surplus of desperate, highly educated workers with no job security (Larson et al. 2014)
- Adjuncts accept poverty wages because they have invested years in specialized training and have few alternatives within academia
- The system is self-perpetuating: each year, more PhDs chase fewer tenured positions, further depressing wages and working conditions

Administrative bloat redirected funding away from teaching faculty

- Non-instructional administrative staff nearly doubled from the 1980s onward (AAUP; Kezar et al.; Ginsberg 2011)
- University president salaries exploded — reaching \$500,000–\$1,000,000+ annually (Ginsberg 2011)
- Meanwhile, adjunct pay remained stagnant and tenure-track lines vanished (Schuster & Finkelstein 2006)
- The budget crisis was manufactured: there was money for expansion and executive compensation, but not for faculty dignity (Ginsberg 2011; Newfield 2016)

Actionable Solutions Exist and Must Be Pursued

Treat educators like the professionals they are

- Teachers and school staff must be trusted and treated as professionals with authority to make day-to-day decisions based on their professional judgment
- Provide time in the workday to plan, prepare, and collaborate with colleagues
- Support ongoing, job-embedded professional development so educators can grow in their careers

Increase salaries and benefits to attract and retain educators

- Provide livable pay tied to the cost of living in each area — too many teachers must work multiple jobs just to make ends meet
- Address the "Adjunct Penalty" — a systemic compensation gap where part-time college faculty are paid a fraction of the salary of full-time, tenure-track professors for performing the same instructional work
 - The piece-rate pay model treats courses as individual units of production rather than as parts of a professional career
 - Average pay is approximately \$4,093 per course as of 2023–24; a standard full-time load (8 courses/year) yields roughly \$32,744 annually
 - In contrast, full-time professors at research universities earn upwards of \$150,000, with even assistant professors typically earning double or triple the average adjunct equivalent
 - The penalty extends beyond salary: only 37% of institutions offer health benefits to adjuncts; fewer than half provide any retirement contributions
 - No Long-Term Contracts: Only 22.5% of adjuncts have contracts providing continued employment; for most, employment is guaranteed only semester-to-semester (AFT 2022)
 - Course Cancellations: At 70% of institutions, courses are canceled if enrollment drops; adjuncts typically receive zero pay for lost work
 - Late Notice: Nearly 43% of adjuncts receive teaching assignments less than one month before classes begin, making financial planning nearly impossible
- Eliminate the burden of heavy student debt — people shouldn't have to go into decades of debt to become teachers

Institutional reform must come from the top

- Convert adjunct lines into full-time, benefits-eligible faculty positions
- Establish minimum per-course compensation standards across institutions

Advocacy and organizing can drive change from below

- Support and expand faculty union efforts at colleges and universities — these efforts are demonstrably working
- At the City University of New York, union negotiations secured three-year appointments for adjuncts meeting certain criteria, providing genuine economic security
- At Rutgers University, the AAUP-AFT negotiated four-semester appointments for part-time faculty with 12+ years of service
- At the University of California, union contracts mandate escalating appointment lengths: one year initially, two years for the second reappointment, and three years for all subsequent appointments
- These contract provisions offer the level of economic security to adjunct faculty that improves material conditions for them and their families
- Amplify adjunct voices in governance and policy conversations

Transparency is the first step toward accountability

- Require public disclosure of faculty compensation data
- Make the adjunct-to-tenure ratio visible in all institutional reporting

Why Higher Education Has Failed: An Ethical Reckoning

Higher education—which should model ethical labor practices and value knowledge work—instead leads the race to the bottom, demonstrating that even terminal degrees offer no protection from exploitation. This sends a chilling message across the economy (Giroux 2014; Slaughter & Rhoades 2004).

The Prestige-Reality Gap and Its Psychological Cost

Academia's prestige masks its exploitative labor practices. From the outside, being a college professor sounds prestigious, intellectual, secure, and middle-class—tenure, summers off, intellectual freedom, respect. The reality of adjuncting—poverty wages, no security, no benefits, no respect, no intellectual life (no time for research or reading), grueling working conditions—shocks people outside academia who assume "professor" means security and status. This gap between cultural perception and lived reality adds to adjuncts' shame and isolation—people don't understand why they're struggling, assume they're exaggerating or bad with money, and offer unhelpful advice ("Just get a real job," "Why did you get a PhD if there are no jobs?") (Childress 2019; Kezar et al.).

The prestige of the PhD becomes a curse: It represents both immense achievement and devastating failure—the credential that was supposed to ensure middle-class security instead ensures precarity (Cassuto; Childress 2019).

Intersectional Exploitation: Who Suffers Most

- **The "mommy penalty" in academia is severe:** Women with children are less likely to be hired, promoted, or tenured, and more likely to be relegated to contingent positions (Misra et al.; Guarino & Borden).
- **Adjuncts of color are less likely to be hired, less likely to be paid fairly, and face racist evaluations from students and administrators that threaten contract renewals** (Griffin et al.; Flaherty).
- **Chronic illnesses may develop or worsen under the stress and deprivation of adjunct life—**autoimmune conditions, cardiovascular disease, diabetes—without access to care (Kenner & Bacon

2019; Childress 2019).

- **International scholars on visas face unique, existential precarity:** visa status (F-1, H-1B, J-1) may depend on continuous employment, making the threat of job loss not just financial but existential (deportation, separation from family, loss of ability to work in the U.S.). They cannot access many safety net benefits U.S. citizens can (unemployment, SNAP, Medicaid), face additional employment restrictions, and may be unable to work second jobs to supplement income. The power imbalance is extreme—institutions hold their ability to remain in the country (Kezar et al.; Childress 2019).

Resistance, Solidarity, and Organizing

Adjunct unionization is growing as instructors organize for better pay, benefits, job security, and working conditions. Unions like SEIU (Service Employees International Union), AFT (American Federation of Teachers), AAUP (American Association of University Professors), and independent faculty unions have organized adjuncts at hundreds of institutions, winning significant improvements: pay increases (sometimes 30-50%+), access to health insurance, job security provisions (seniority systems, multi-year contracts), grievance procedures, professional development funding, and inclusion in governance. Unionization has measurably improved adjunct working conditions where it exists (Berry; Rhoades; McNaughtan et al.).

Adjunct organizing faces intense opposition from administrations who threaten, intimidate, surveil, and retaliate against organizers, delay contract negotiations for years, claim poverty while sitting on massive endowments, and manipulate worker classifications to prevent unionization (Berry; Rhoades).

Landmark campaigns like the "Adjunct Project" collected data crowdsourcing adjunct pay rates, exposing the exploitation and making it visible. The #AdjunctCrisis hashtag campaigns raised awareness

National Adjunct Walkout Day and organizing efforts have made the exploitation visible, disrupted operations, and forced public conversations. Media coverage of adjunct poverty (articles in The Atlantic, The Chronicle of Higher Education, Inside Higher Ed) has changed public perception (Berry; Childress 2019).

Student solidarity matters and is growing. When students understand that their instructors are struggling—living in cars, skipping meals, unable to afford healthcare—they can advocate for better institutional practices, recognize that their education quality is tied to instructor working conditions, and join campaigns demanding change. Students have organized rallies, written petitions, testified at board meetings, and refused to cross picket lines in support of adjunct faculty (Berry; McNaughtan et al.).

Student-adjunct alliances are powerful because students have moral authority and institutions care about their satisfaction (customers) in ways they don't care about adjunct well-being (Berry).

Some institutions have converted adjunct lines to full-time lecturer positions with better pay (\$40,000-\$60,000+), benefits, multi-year contracts (3-5 years), pathways to continuing/permanent status, and inclusion in governance—proving that change is possible when there's political will. These conversions should be celebrated as victories while recognizing they're insufficient—the goal should be tenure-track or equivalent permanent positions (McNaughtan et al.; Rhoades).

Resistance comes at great personal risk for adjuncts, who can be easily fired for organizing, speaking publicly, or even just associating with union efforts. Contingent workers have none of the academic freedom protections that tenure provides. Organizers have been blacklisted across institutions, had contracts not renewed in retaliation, faced legal threats, and experienced professional destruction for demanding basic dignity. The courage required to organize under these conditions is immense (Berry; Bousquet).

Tenure-track faculty solidarity is essential but often lacking. Some tenured faculty organize alongside contingent colleagues, using their privilege and protection to shield vulnerable workers. Others ignore, minimize, or benefit from exploitation, enjoying smaller classes and reduced service because adjuncts absorb the teaching and are excluded from governance. Academic labor solidarity across tiers is necessary for transformative change (Berry; Rhoades; American Association of University Professors).

What Justice Demands

Adjuncts should earn:

- Salaries proportional to their education, expertise, and workload—minimum \$60,000-\$75,000 for full-time equivalent teaching (4-5 courses per semester) or \$8,000-\$10,000 per course minimum for actual part-time work
- Full health insurance, employer retirement contributions, paid sick leave (minimum 10-15 days), parental leave, and professional development funding (American Association of University Professors; "New AFT Report: Adjunct Faculty Remain Underpaid")

Adjuncts deserve:

- Multi-year contracts (3-5 years minimum) for all contingent positions, with transparent renewal processes, clear criteria, due process, presumption of renewal absent cause, pathways to permanent/continuing status after reasonable time periods, and grievance procedures ("Adjuncts Emphasize Need for Contracts"; Kezar et al.; Berry)
- Private office space or dedicated shared offices with privacy, institutional email and IT support, library and database access, professional development funding, parking permits, and inclusion in all communications (Coalition on the Academic Workforce; American Federation of Teachers)
- Explicit payment for office hours, student advising, email, service, committee work, course development, assessment, meetings, recommendation letters, and all other academic labor—not subsuming these into per-course rates (Magness; American Federation of Teachers)
- Publicly available pay rates, clear promotion policies, written contracts at least 6 months in advance, and elimination of contracts issued after semester begins ("Adjuncts Emphasize Need for Contracts"; Government Accountability Office)

Mental health and wellness support:

- Free confidential counseling services equivalent to tenure-track faculty access (Tucker et al. 2022; Evans et al. 2018)
- Paid mental health days and medical leave provisions (American Federation of Teachers)
- Institutional cultures that normalize help-seeking and treat mental health as systemic workplace issue, not individual failing (Evans et al. 2018; Levecque et al. 2017)
- Subsidized or free health insurance for all adjuncts, regardless of hours or status ("An Army of Temps"; "Adjunct Faculty | Current Employees")

Governance and voice:

- Full voting rights in curriculum decisions, hiring committees, departmental governance, and faculty senate for all faculty regardless of employment status (Rhoades; American Association of University Professors)

Systemic transformation:

- Reinvest in public higher education: State and federal funding to lower tuition, expand tenure-track positions, reduce adjunct reliance, and reverse decades of disinvestment (Newfield 2016; "Recent Trends in the Cost of College")
- Cultural change: Value teaching as core academic work, equal to or more important than research; respect and recognize adjunct labor; end the prestige hierarchy that devalues teaching; and challenge the exploitation as morally unconscionable (Childress 2019; Bousquet; Giroux 2014)

The Moral Imperative

Higher education is a public good, essential to democracy, social mobility, innovation, and informed citizenship, and its quality depends fundamentally on the well-being, stability, and support of its instructors. Exploiting adjuncts degrades education for everyone—not just adjuncts, but students who deserve excellent teaching and society that depends on educated citizens (Newfield 2016; Readings; Giroux 2014).

Students are being cheated. They (and their families, and taxpayers in public systems) pay tens of thousands of dollars in tuition expecting quality education from supported, secure, fairly compensated educators who can invest fully in their learning—not instructors living in cars and cycling through multiple institutions just to survive. The financial exploitation of adjuncts subsidizes administrative bloat, luxury facilities, and endowment growth while undermining the core mission of teaching and learning ("Recent Trends in the Cost of College"; Ginsberg 2011; Figlio et al. 2015).

The social contract is broken—a betrayal and fraud. Society told these individuals to get advanced degrees, that education was the path to stable, meaningful work and middle-class security, that a PhD was the highest achievement guaranteeing respect and livelihood. Then it abandoned them to poverty and precarity, blaming them for circumstances structurally created. This betrayal undermines faith in education, meritocracy, and institutions (Cassuto; Childress 2019; Bousquet).

This is a moral issue and human rights crisis. Allowing highly educated, skilled people to live in poverty—experiencing food and housing insecurity, unable to access healthcare, suffering mental health crises without support—while administrators earn \$500,000-\$1,000,000+ salaries and universities accumulate billion-dollar endowments is morally unconscionable, a grotesque injustice that violates basic human dignity. We have the resources; we're choosing not to use them to support human beings doing essential work ("How Harvard University's Funding Works"; "Report Shows Alarming Poverty"; Kenner & Bacon 2019; Ginsberg 2011).

Conclusion

The adjunct crisis is not an accident, a natural market outcome, or a temporary budget problem—it's a deliberate, systematic restructuring of higher education that prioritizes profit maximization over people, educational mission, and human dignity (Bousquet; Slaughter & Rhoades 2004; Kezar et al.), exploits workers' passion, credentials, and desperation (Childress 2019; Cassuto), and treats teaching—the core work of education—as a commodity and expendable gig work rather than a skilled profession worthy of investment, support, and respect (Umbach 2007; Ehrenberg & Zhang 2005).

Highly educated, deeply committed, brilliant instructors are living in poverty, experiencing food and housing insecurity (Kenner & Bacon 2019; "Report Shows Alarming Poverty"; Goldrick-Rab et al. 2015), suffering mental health crises without access to care (Evans et al. 2018; Levecque et al. 2017; Tucker et al. 2022), and being denied the basic dignity of stable employment and living wages—all while doing the majority of undergraduate teaching at American colleges and universities (June; Johnson & Fuesting 2026; American Association of University Professors) and being told their exploitation is necessary, inevitable, or somehow

their own fault for "choosing" humanities fields or not being "competitive enough" for jobs that don't exist (Cassuto; Larson et al. 2014; Roy et al.).

This system harms adjuncts catastrophically, degrades educational quality measurably (Umbach 2007; Figlio et al. 2015; Jaeger & Eagan), betrays students who deserve better ("Their Wellbeing Affects Our Wellbeing"; Ehrenberg & Zhang 2005), and corrupts the mission and integrity of higher education as an institution dedicated to knowledge, truth, and human flourishing (Readings; Ginsberg 2011; Giroux 2014).

Adjuncts are not "temporary," "supplemental," or "part-time"—they are the teaching workforce

(Johnson & Fuesting 2026; Government Accountability Office), and they deserve living wages that allow them to afford housing and healthcare, job security that allows them to plan beyond the current semester, full benefits including health insurance and retirement, respect as the credentialed professionals and experts they are, offices and resources to do their work effectively, and the institutional support necessary to teach well and live with dignity (American Association of University Professors; "New AFT Report: Adjunct Faculty Remain Underpaid"; Berry).

Until higher education reckons honestly with this exploitation, names it as such, and commits to transformative structural change—not cosmetic improvements or small pay bumps, but fundamental reinvestment in teaching as valued work deserving of tenure-track or equivalent permanent, secure, fairly compensated positions (Kezar et al.; Schuster & Finkelstein 2006; Newfield 2016)—the crisis will deepen, more brilliant people will be destroyed by a system that trained them and then discarded them (Cassuto; Childress 2019; Evans et al. 2018), and everyone invested in education, knowledge, justice, and human dignity should be outraged, organizing, and demanding better (Berry; Rhoades; Bousquet).

The current system is morally bankrupt, intellectually indefensible, and unsustainable. We can do better. We must do better. Adjuncts, students, and the future of education depend on it.

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